

JOHN W. BARRY

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ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Rice University	Houston, TX
Assistant Professor of Finance	2024-

EDUCATION

Duke University, Fuqua School of Business	Durham, NC
PhD, Finance	2018-2024
Barcelona School of Economics	Barcelona, Spain
MS, International Trade, Finance and Development (ITFD)	2015-2016
Trinity College Dublin	Dublin, Ireland
BA, Philosophy, Politics, Economics & Sociology (PPES)	2009-2013

WORKING PAPERS

Beyond the Ballot: Shareholder Engagement and Governance Dynamics

with Andrey Malenko and Nadya Malenko (August 2026) [Latest version](#)

This paper studies how private engagement and public voting jointly shape shareholder governance. Using data on large asset managers' pay-related engagements and say-on-pay votes, we show that both channels respond to disagreement between investors and boards, and that engagement predicts lower future CEO compensation and less subsequent dissent. We develop and estimate a structural model in which engagement and voting are interacting governance channels that determine what investors and boards learn and how CEO pay evolves. The model shows why votes can be misleading in isolation: support for management can reflect concerns resolved through prior engagement, rather than shareholder passivity. It also allows us to evaluate recent regulatory initiatives that may restrict engagement or voting. Our counterfactuals show that restrictions on one channel shift investor activity toward the other, but substitution is incomplete: engagement allows richer information exchange, while voting also disciplines management.

Human Capital, Competition and Mobility in the Managerial Labor Market

with Noah Lyman and Lin Zhao (August 2026) [Latest version](#), [SSRN](#)

We pose a structural model of the managerial labor market with general and firm-specific human capital accumulation, internal and external mobility, managerial bargaining power, and imperfect labor market competition. The model reconciles high pay with low mobility: outside offers can improve incumbent contracts without producing job switches. Firm-specific skill is central to this mechanism: it strengthens incumbent matches, raising poaching costs and weakening the leverage of a given outside offer. Competition therefore operates through renegotiation with incumbents: bargaining power alone would give managers 31.6% of match surplus, while competition lifts realized capture to 54.6%, and to 79.3% for externally hired CEOs. Making firm-specific skill portable shifts competitive gains from renegotiation toward mobility, increasing job switching, external CEO hiring, and manager welfare.

Shareholder Voice and Executive Compensation

(May 2026) [Latest version](#), [SSRN](#)

I estimate a model of CEO compensation with nonbinding shareholder approval votes (Say-on-Pay): shareholders can dissent on compensation decisions and punish the Board. Because the compensation proposal is endogenous to the voting environment itself, the threat of dissent disciplines pay ex ante and increases shareholder value by 2.97% on average, despite a 6% failure rate. I analyze counterfactual vote designs that alter the intervention and communication aspects of the vote. Binding votes pin pay to the last approved policy and may ignore new information about CEO ability. Designs that strengthen intervention while incorporating vote-revealed information may best benefit shareholders.

Information and Preferences in Shareholder Voting

with James Pinnington and Lin Zhao (July 2026) [Latest version](#), [SSRN](#)

We develop a structural model of shareholder voting under incomplete information about proposal quality. Preferences and information are not separately identified from individual voting patterns: correlated information and strategic voting jointly determine the mapping from preferences to votes. Our identification strategy uses proxy advisor recommendations as observable measures of public information and vote co-movement across shareholders to identify the information environment; preferences are then pinned down by the voting equilibrium. Despite higher support for management, blockholders' preferences towards passage of management proposals are close to dispersed shareholders': the gap reflects inference from pivotality. Differences in information quality affect voting outcomes more than differences in preferences.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Executive Mobility in the United States, 1920-2023

with John Graham, Hyunseob Kim and Dawoon Kim (August 2026)

This paper studies the evolution of U.S. public corporations' executive mobility from 1920 to 2023. The executives' mobility exhibits a secular increase from the 1920s through the turn of the century. After peaking in the late-1990s, it declined sharply and stabilized at a lower level: chief executive mobility in the 2010s is less than half its late-1990s peak, returning to levels of the 1960s and 1970s. Finance-chief mobility shows a stronger secular rise over the century. We argue that changes in the size of the executive labor market, the redeployability of executive skills, and capital reallocation explain these trends. Using a shift-share design, we show that the mobility impacts executive pay structure.

PUBLICATIONS

Hurdle Rate Buffers and Bargaining Power in Asset Acquisition

with Bruce Carlin, Alan Crane and John Graham (April 2026)

[Journal of Financial Economics](#)

Corporate Flexibility in a Time of Crisis

with Murillo Campello, John Graham and Yueran Ma (June 2022)

[Journal of Financial Economics](#)

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

- 2026:** IAF, FIRS, DSE Summer School Conference, NFA ($\times 2$)[†], Oktoberfest Finance[†], Vienna Festival of Finance Theory, European Finance Association
- 2025:** SWFA, ITAM Finance Conference, Univ. Amsterdam, IAF, FIRS, UNSW Corporate Finance, NBER Economics of Executive Compensation, FMA ($\times 2$), Berlin Labor & Finance
- 2024:** Toulouse School of Economics, CEMFI, Cornell University, Notre Dame University, Rice University, Ohio State University, UMass Amherst, MIT Sloan, Boston College, University of Maryland, Vanderbilt University, UVA Darden, MFA, Eastern Finance, Aarhus Strategic Interactions Workshop, Lone Star Finance Symposium, UTD Finance Conference
- 2023:** AFA, LBS TADC, Inter-Finance PhD Seminar, Duke IO lunch, Fuqua, Olin Finance Conference PhD Poster Session, Boca Finance Conference [†]= scheduled

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor	Rice University
Advanced Corporate Finance (Undergraduate)	2025-
Advanced Corporate Finance (MBA)	2025-
Head Teaching Assistant	Duke University
Corporate Finance (MBA)	2019-2023
Empirical Methods in Corporate Finance (PhD)	2019-2023
Pre-PhD	International House Dublin & Huelva
English Teacher	2013-2015

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

- Referee:** Journal of Finance, Review of Financial Studies, Review of Finance, Management Science, Journal of Corporate Finance, Financial Management, American Economic Review: Insights, Journal of Human capital, American Economic Review, Journal of Banking & Finance